POWERPLAY — Player Primer

A first-timer's walkthrough. Read this once, then keep the reference cards (Quick / Round / Turn / Mechanics / Ladder & Turn) handy at the table.

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1. Welcome to the Boardroom

PowerPlay is a corporate-satire strategy card and token game for **3–5 players**. Each player runs a thinly-disguised shell of an industrial empire, trying to amass more **Power** than the rest of the table by the end of the fiscal year.

You'll buy **Assets** (Tier 1 → Tier 3), play **Actions** to attack the competition, **React** when you're attacked, and convert **Coins** → **Influence** → **Power** at every opportunity.

The game runs **4 rounds** — one round per fiscal quarter, a full fiscal year per game. Each player takes **8 turns** (2 per round).

> *"In a free market, your value is whatever you can convince someone else it is."*

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2. What's on the Table

The CEOs have catered the boardroom. When the table is set up, you should see:

- **7 card piles**:
  - 1 **Action** deck (a single pile — no tiers) — what you do TO other players.
  - 1 **Reaction** deck (a single pile — no tiers) — how you respond when something happens TO you.
  - 3 **Asset** piles (T1, T2, T3) — the companies you buy that generate income.
  - 1 **Event** deck — the market events that hit everyone, twice a round.
  - 1 **Character** deck — the personas you'll pick from at setup.
- **Per-player counters** (one set at each seat): **Power (P)**, **Influence (IP)**, **Coins (C)**, **Loans**.
- **Power Track** (one dial per seat) — tracks your current Power on a face reading **0–9, then 10 → 100**. Labels mark what each level unlocks: **1 = PowerPlay!**, **2 = Tier 2 and your Character Ability**, **3 = Tier 3**. It's just a visible readout of your Power (the win condition *and* your tier-access gate) — move the dial up or down as you gain or spend Power.
- **Per-color IOU template** (one per seat color) — used to record debts owed to that color player.
- **Income dice** — a D4, D6, and D10 (you roll one per Asset tier you own at the Opening Bell).
- **One Leader Token** that travels around the table each round.

> ⚠ ***Quick orientation****: Power is the win condition and your access gate. Influence buys the Influencing Decision (a third Asset fire) and converts into Power. Coins buy Assets and cards and pay debts. You'll convert between them constantly.*

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3. Setup, Step by Step (The Shareholder Onboarding Packet)

1. **Pick a character.** The Character deck is the only deck dealt face-up at setup — each player picks one. Your character has printed **Starting Stats** (Coins and Influence) and a special **Character Ability**. Set your counters to those starting values. **Every character starts with 0 Power** — Power is earned entirely in play. Set your Power Track dial to 0.
2. **Deal Starting Hand.** Each player draws **3 Action cards** and **2 Reaction cards** from the Action and Reaction decks. All Action and Reaction cards are free to play, with no Power requirement — every player can use their starting hand immediately.
3. **Determine the Leader.** Pick the first player by one of the Manual's (gloriously arbitrary) tiebreakers — most recent foreign trip, priciest watch or car, or who used the toilet last — and give them the **Leader Token** for Round 1. *(Everyone starts at 0 Power, so it's not a Power contest.)*
4. **Hand refill target**: 3 Actions + 2 Reactions. Your hand is refilled to this at the start of each round (Opening Bell), not capped per turn — during the round you simply play your hand down. There's no end-of-turn discard.
5. **Done.** Your first Morning News phase begins now. The game runs 4 rounds — no length to choose.

> ⚠ ***Tip****: Don't agonize over character choice — every character is built to the same equity standard, so there's no objectively-best pick. Pick the one whose ability fits how you like to play (information, trading, or capital).*

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4. The Round in 7 Phases (One Fiscal Quarter)

The market opens, the market gossips, the market closes. A round batches all the upkeep up front so that when it's finally your turn, you just *play*. Every phase runs in **turn order from the Leader** unless noted, in this order:

Phase 1 — Morning News

- Draw 1 Event card (the **Morning News**) and **read it aloud**, then resolve it. Some Events fire once and end ("one-shot"); others stay active ("ongoing") **until the next round's Morning News replaces this one**. Every Event also carries an **Event Objective** — an easy-to-check goal that pays **1 Power** to *any* player who hits it (in the moment, once each). Climbing Power this way is the main route to bigger tiers.

Phase 2 — Opening Bell (Batch Upkeep)

This is where the boring-but-vital quarterly housekeeping happens, all at once, before anyone takes a turn. In turn order:

- **Draw Hands**: discard any cards you don't want, then **refill to 3 Action + 2 Reaction** (this refill is free).
- **Income Roll**: roll **one die per Asset tier you own** — **T1 = D4, T2 = D6, T3 = D10** — all at once. The **number on the die is the Coins you collect per Asset** of that tier — Frozen Assets still earn income (a freeze only locks the Synergy). Pay **Operating Costs first** (T2: 1 C each; T3: 2 C each; T1: none). The **Income Reroll** lets you pay 2 C to reroll any one die.

That's the whole phase — free hand refill and income. Card *buying* is not here: it happens at **The Inbox**, the start of each of your turns (§ 5).

> ⚠ ***Why up front?*** *Everyone has fresh hands and fresh income before the bidding and the turns begin — so the Market Operation draft (next) is a real liquidity fight.*

Phase 3 — Market Operation (Pre-Market Sealed-Bid Draft)

Opt in if you want to shop. In turn order from the Leader, each participant pulls one Asset into a shared row (gated by Pull eligibility — T1: any participant; T2: 2 P **and** 4 Coins; T3: 3 P **and** 7 Coins). Everyone then **secretly commits a Coin bid** in a closed hand and reveals at once. The highest bid picks any eligible Asset and **pays their bid** (minimum ½ its printed cost — T1 ≥ 2 / T2 ≥ 4 / T3 ≥ 7), then the next-highest picks, and so on. Down to 1 Coin? You bid it all-in, resolve last, and grab a leftover. Ties go to turn order from the Leader. Leftovers go to the bottom of their decks. The Draft is the cheap, competitive way to buy — the Lunch Break's Private Equity is the pricier, on-demand way.

> ⚠ ***Draft subtlety****: Bidding is blind and you pay exactly what you bid — overbid and you overpay, underbid and a rival snipes the Asset you wanted. Pulling a pricey card into the row can also bait a competitor into spending big.*

> ⚠ ***Tip****: don't bid away your whole wallet — keep a Coin or two in reserve for Inbox card purchases (Action 2 C / Reaction 1 C) on your upcoming turn. (Synergy activation itself costs no Coins — the reserve is for Inbox buying only.)*

Phase 4 — Market Manipulation, Phase 1 (First Turns)

Every player takes their **first** turn, clockwise from the Leader. Each turn is short: **The Inbox → Action → Organize the Desk** (next section).

Phase 5 — Lunch Break (Mid-Round Economy)

When play returns to the Leader, the table breaks for deals. Five sub-phases, in this order, each in turn order from the Leader:

1. **Afternoon News** — draw + read aloud a *second* Event card. It stays active **until the next round's Afternoon News** — so it carries over into the next round's first half, and two Events (Morning + Afternoon) are live at once, each with its own Event Objective.
2. **Loans** — borrow ½ an unmortgaged Asset's printed cost (rounded down); that Asset becomes Mortgaged. Loans come first so the borrowed Coins can fund the deals that follow.
3. **Trading Window** — voluntary two-party deals; eligible contents include **Action / Reaction cards (from hand), Asset cards (ownership transfers), Coins, and IOUs**. **Cap: 2 deals max per player per Trading Window.** A creditor may also **sell an outstanding IOU to a third party** here — the buyer collects from the original debtor at Call-it-a-Night. *Influence and Power are NOT tradable; converting your own resources isn't trading.*
4. **Private Equity (Broker an Asset Deal)** — pay a fee (1 C for T1, 2 C for T2, 3 C for T3), draw the top 2 of one Asset deck you qualify for, buy one at printed cost (with its Signing Bonus), discard the other.
5. **Sells** — sell an unmortgaged Asset to the bank, or to another player, for its printed cost. Mortgaged Assets cannot be sold.

Phase 6 — Market Manipulation, Phase 2 (Second Turns)

Every player takes their **second** turn.

Phase 7 — Call-it-a-Night

End-of-round bookkeeping — each player settles their **own** affairs, in turn order. (Trading already happened at the Lunch Break.) In this order:

1. **Currency Conversion**: convert your own Tokens at the standard rates — **3 C = 1 IP**, **2 IP = 1 P**. Any amounts, forward only.
2. **Debt Settlement** (loans + IOUs — see § 8 for details).
3. **Thievery**: if the **lowest-Power player** isn't already the Leader, they take the Leader Token and assign it to ANY player — including themselves. Ties → the earliest player in turn order decides.

If this wasn't the final round, the next round starts at Morning News. If it was, run **Clean the Books** (all outstanding loans settle now) and then the **Board Meeting** (final scoring).

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5. The Turn in 3 Phases (Your Time on the Mic)

Your turn is lean. The heavy upkeep — drawing your hand and collecting income — already happened at the **Opening Bell**. Selling, lending, and trading happen at the **Lunch Break**. Your turn is: **The Inbox** → **Action** → **Organize the Desk**. Make it billable.

A. The Inbox

At the **start of your turn**, you may buy cards — up to one of each:

- **Action card**: pay **2 Coins**, draw the top 2 of the Action deck, keep 1, discard the other.
- **Reaction card**: pay **1 Coin**, draw the top 2 of the Reaction deck, keep 1, discard the other.

Buying is optional — 0, 1, or 2 cards per turn. Note the pricing: Actions cost *more* than Reactions, because an Action card fires up to 3 of your Assets while a Reaction fires 1. There's no safety net — if you're out of cards *and* out of Coins, you wait for the next Opening Bell's free refill.

B. Action

You may take **one Standard Action** — and there's exactly one thing on the menu:

- **Play an Action card** — free to play. Resolve the card's base effect, and **2 of your Assets matching the card's primary Industry fire their Synergy clauses for free** (the Base). You may pay **1 Influence** for the **Influencing Decision**: the card's secondary Industry is unlocked and **1 more Asset fires** (from either Industry) — **3 fires total**. There are no Coin activation costs. Fires resolve **one at a time, in the order you choose**; each targeted player gets a chance to React before their fire resolves.

Leaving your Standard Action unused is allowed — no reward, no penalty.

Free Actions don't consume your Standard Action:

- **Character Ability** — once per round (across both your turns), **free** — no Coin, Influence, or Power cost. You must **hold at least 2 Power** to use it (checked, not spent), and each ability names the **specific phase** it can be used in — check your character card. Note that most abilities fire during round phases (Opening Bell, Market Operation, Lunch Break, Call-it-a-Night), not during your turn.
- **PowerPlay!** — pay 1 P → you may **play up to 2 Action cards this turn**; **one of them gets the Influencing Decision for free** (the other can still buy it for 1 Influence); draw 1 Action + 1 Reaction; and you may **declare up to 2 Asset Synergy fires Sacred** this turn. Once per turn. **Sacred**. This is the standard way to take a *second* action.

> ⚠ ***Big subtle rule****: PowerPlay! works even after you've already played your first Action card — you can still unlock and play the second one. So PowerPlay! into a second Action card play is a common combo when you have the Power to spend.*

C. Organize the Desk

- **Attach cleanup** — remove any expired Attached cards from your Assets and from yourself. **A Freeze is just an Attached "freeze" card** — clearing it here is how a Frozen Asset unfreezes.

> ⚠ ***No discard step.*** *You don't trim your hand at end of turn — you just play your hand down through the round, and it refills at the next Opening Bell. Loan upkeep and repayment live at the Lunch Break / Call-it-a-Night, not here.*

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6. What Can I Do on My Turn? (The Quarterly Strategy Memo)

A common new-player confusion: **what exactly counts as a "Standard Action"?** The Board pays for exactly one per turn — and there's only one thing on that menu:

Choice	Cost	Effect
Play Action card	Free (optional: 1 Influence for the Influencing Decision)	Resolve the card's effect; **2 primary-Industry Assets fire** for free (3 fires, with the secondary Industry unlocked, if you buy the Influencing Decision). *(The only Standard Action.)*

Selling Assets, taking Loans, and brokering deals are not turn actions — they happen at the **Lunch Break** (§ 4). And these are NOT Standard Actions — they don't use up your Action slot:

Free	When	Effect
Character Ability	During the phase printed on your character card (once per round)	Free — no cost. Requires you to hold **2 Power** (checked, not spent).
PowerPlay!	Any time on your turn (once per turn)	Pay 1 P → play up to 2 Action cards this turn (one gets the Influencing Decision free) + draw 1 A + 1 R + declare up to 2 Synergy fires Sacred. Sacred.
Asset Synergy	Automatically, when you play a card whose Industry matches the Asset	The Asset's Synergy fires through the Activation Ladder — you pick the target.

> ⚠ ***Where did selling/loans/buying go?*** *The free hand refill and the income roll are at the* ***Opening Bell*** *(start of round). Buying cards is at* ***The Inbox*** *(start of each of your turns — Action 2 C, Reaction 1 C). Selling Assets, taking Loans, and Private Equity deals are at the* ***Lunch Break*** *(mid-round).*

Example turn: It's Market Manipulation Phase 1 and it's your turn. (You already drew your 3A/2R hand and collected income at the Opening Bell, and you bought into an Asset at the Market Operation draft.) The Inbox — you pay 2 Coins to buy an Action card: draw the top 2 of the Action deck, keep 1, discard the other. Action phase — you play "Hostile Takeover" (free); its base effect resolves and 2 of your Assets matching its primary Industry fire their Synergy clauses, one at a time in the order you choose. You pay 1 Influence for the Influencing Decision, unlocking the card's secondary Industry — a 3rd Asset fires. The opponent Counters one of the fires with a Reaction. You PowerPlay! (1 P): you may now play a second Action card this turn, one of your Actions gets its Influencing Decision free, and you draw 1 A + 1 R. You play "Smear Campaign" as that second Action. Organize the Desk — clear any expired attachments (an attached Freeze would come off here). Done. (You'll get your *second* turn this round in Phase 6, after the Lunch Break.)

> ⚠ ***Newbie trap****: You may have only* ***1 Standard Action****, but you can also use* ***1 Character Ability*** *per round and* ***1 PowerPlay!*** *per turn. Plus you can play Reactions on other players' turns. The "I can only do one thing" feeling is wrong — read the Turn Reference Card carefully.*

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7. Reactions and How to Defend Yourself (Crisis Comms)

Reactions are cards you play **out of turn** — responses. They live in your hand the same way Actions do, and you play one when something is happening TO you (or to a player you choose to defend): an Action card play, an individual Asset Synergy fire, or an Event. Think of them as the legal team on retainer: you wait until something bad is happening, then unleash them.

Four things to know:

1. **Any Reaction can Counter any Action** — or any *individual* Synergy fire. There are no tier restrictions (the Action and Reaction decks have no tiers). Each Asset fire is a separate event with its own response window, so a 3-fire Action gives up to 3 separate Counter opportunities.

2. **Reactions mitigate, they don't erase.** Playing a Reaction reduces or compensates for what's hitting you — it doesn't fully negate the Action or fire.
3. **No Reaction-to-Reaction.** A Reaction can never be played in response to another Reaction — the chain ends at the first Reaction, every time.
4. **Response only.** You can't play a Reaction proactively on your own turn — a Reaction always answers a trigger (an Action, a fire, or an Event).

> ⚠ ***Reactor vocabulary**: The player who plays a Reaction is called the **Reactor**. You can Reaction-defend YOURSELF or any other player (the affected player always gets first right to respond). When you play a Reaction, **1 of YOUR matching-Industry Assets fires** its Synergy clause automatically — it checks YOUR Assets, not the Defender's.*

Sacred plays open no response window at all — no Reaction can be played against them, period. Sacred covers PowerPlay! itself and Asset Synergy fires declared Sacred via PowerPlay!.

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8. Money, Loans, and Going Broke (Capital Discipline)

Currency conversion

At Call-it-a-Night (only), or any time a card explicitly allows it:

- **3 Coins = 1 Influence**
- **2 Influence = 1 Power**

Going the other way isn't allowed. *(Converting your own resources is not trading — and Influence and Power themselves cannot be traded to other players.)*

Loans

Take a Loan at the **Lunch Break** (or during Bankruptcy Resolution) — it is never a turn action. The bank pays you up to **floor(Asset cost / 2)** Coins; you lien an Asset of your choice as collateral (it's now **Mortgaged**).

- **Max 2 active loans** per player.
- **Maintenance fee**: 1 C per active loan at Call-it-a-Night, **except** the round you acquired the loan (grace round).
- **Voluntary repay** (at Call-it-a-Night): pay **principal + 1 C** → the Asset is unmortgaged.
- **Default** (missed maintenance OR over-cap): the mortgaged Asset goes to the discard pile, the bank pays you its printed cost, you pay back the loan dues, and you **keep the surplus** (1 C / 3 C / 6 C for T1/T2/T3). No elimination from loan default.
- **Mortgaged Assets still earn income** — the loan just claims the collateral if you default.
- **Mortgaged Assets cannot be sold** — repay the loan first to unmortgage the Asset before selling it.

IOUs

If an Action card demands a resource you don't have (insufficient IP, Power, or Coin), you take a **Coin-denominated IOU** to the Attacker instead.

Shortfall	IOU value (per missing unit)
1 IP	4 C (3 + 1 interest)
1 P	7 C (6 + 1 interest)
1 C	(X + 1) C

- **Cap**: max 2 NEW IOUs per Defender per round. Subsequent debt triggers floor at 0 (you just can't pay anymore).
- **Settlement**: at Call-it-a-Night, in Debt Settlement after Currency Conversion. Voluntary repay first, then negotiation, then forced liquidation.
- **Negotiation is open-ended**: forgive part, trade an Asset for partial credit, swap for future favors (non-binding!). Both parties have to agree.
- **Tradable**: the IOU holder can sell the IOU to a third party in the Lunch Break Trading Window — the buyer then collects from you.

Bankruptcy

Going to 0 Coins isn't bankrupt — you're just broke. **Bankrupt** means you owe Coins and can't pay even after liquidating every unencumbered Asset. Outcomes:

- **Loan default → NOT elimination**. The bank takes the Asset; you keep the surplus.
- **IOU default WITH a negotiated agreement → NOT elimination**. The Attacker forgives, partial-pays, or accepts an Asset trade.
- **IOU default with no unencumbered Assets AND no agreement → elimination**. Your owed IOUs and any held IOUs are wiped from play.

> ⚠ ***Cushion strategy***: *Keep at least 1 unencumbered (un-mortgaged) Asset in reserve. It's your safety net against forced IOU liquidation.*

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9. How You Win (The Board Meeting)

At the end of the final Round, after the last Call-it-a-Night runs, the Board convenes to determine who walks out the **POWER PLAYER**. Two steps happen:

1. **Clean the Books**: every outstanding loan settles now. Pay principal + 1 C to clear, or default (Asset → discard, bank pays you printed cost, you keep the surplus). **No elimination from loan default at this step either.**
2. **Board Meeting** — final scoring:

```
Total Power = Power
            + floor(IP / 2)
            + floor(Coins / 6)
            + floor(Asset Value / 5)
```

Where "Asset Value" is the sum of printed costs of every Asset you still own (4 C / 8 C / 14 C for T1/T2/T3).

> ⚠ ***Why the rates differ***: *Coins score at* `/6`*, Asset Value at* `/5`*. Owning Assets is intentionally a slightly better score-per-token than hoarding liquid Coins. Convert Coins to Assets when you can.*

Highest Total Power wins. Ties broken by best-of-three Rock / Paper / Scissors / Lizard / Spock. (Yes, really.)

Sample scoring: A player ends with **5 Power, 7 Influence, 15 Coins**, and two T2 Assets (printed cost 8 C each = 16 C Asset Value).

```
Total Power = 5 + floor(7/2) + floor(15/6) + floor(16/5)
            = 5 +    3       +    2        +    3
            = 13
```

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10. Where to Look Next (The Compliance Library)

The reference cards on the table — keep them visible; the Board appreciates due diligence:

- **Quick Reference** — one-page summary of every system. Keep this in front of you.
- **Round Reference Card** — one-page detailed walkthrough of the 7 round phases (Morning News → Opening Bell → Market Operation → Market Manipulation Phases 1 & 2, with the Lunch Break between → Call-it-a-Night).
- **Turn Reference Card** — one-page detailed walkthrough of The Inbox → Action → Organize the Desk.
- **Ladder & Turn Reference** — the Activation Ladder, PowerPlay!, Power Floors, and Reactions on one card.
- **Mechanics Reference Card** — every named mechanic (Power Floor, Sacred, Countering, IOU, Loan, Attach, etc.) defined precisely.

The full rules manual is comprehensive — but the cards above will get you through almost every situation that comes up at the table. Save the manual for rules debates and edge cases.

Good luck. Try not to get eliminated. And if you do, remember: it's only fictional money.